

we threw out the entire hardware and software and, instead, developed our own ERP solution using the LAMP stack, i.e., Linux Apache MySQL and PHP (OS, Web host, database and language) running on LTSP.

Addressing the lack of talent

When we were at the learning stage, hiring the right talent was a big challenge. I wanted to extend my team both in terms of numbers and capabilities. So I approached professional technical colleges. We invited students looking for six month training/internships as per the mandate of their respective curricula. For a month, we gave them the liberty of exploring the Internet; this was at a time when accessing it was costly. We expected them to learn and utilise our resources. In return, we asked them to submit customised projects for the small problems we faced in our ecosystem. The potential of their projects decided their future within our company.

As a result of this approach, we implemented our own open source based ERP system. There was no compromise on security as we never came across a virus attack or data loss.

I respect the concept of the mailing list

I love the concept of the mailing list, especially for open source. The mailing list and its later avatar, the forum, are all about sharing knowledge. It is like a broadcast that gets you possible solutions to specific problems. Not just for software or hardware, there are virtually thousands upon thousands of mailing lists and forums for physical ailments.

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In open source, 'free' does not mean zero cost, but freedom—the freedom to use, freedom to change and the freedom to redistribute.
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At one point, I was very active on a handful of mailing lists and a silent reader on three times more. I used to help the right people connect with each other or with possible solution builders. In all such activities, the reference to the context is important, since it is serious stuff. Nobody offers handholding on these lists but there are so many willing to help that it is unbelievable. A current favourite example is Quora. Ask and you get the answers.

LUGs and open source events like Foss.In, Freed.In and Linux Asia presented opportunities to meet with other like-minded people. Getting and giving advice to others was key at these events.

This is just the beginning...

Today, we see India contributing to the world of open source. Vtiger CRM is one such example, which enables you to deliver memorable customer experiences in every interaction across the customer's life cycle.

To emphasise on the future of open source technology, I would say what Sir Isaac Newton said in 1675: "If I have seen further, it is by standing on the shoulders of giants." I didn't do anything great — whatever I achieved is because there was a base available for me to start from. This again brings me to the concept of the community and the mailing list.

We should study the ideology of open source, to understand its essence. The concept of open source is very rebellious. Why get into a forced and costly relationship (I mean, with proprietary technology)? Open source allowed me to swim freely and shape my journey, which is its key trait. 

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